my body. What I have done will endure, not what I have said or written.' Gandhi was an artful choreographer of his doings – he seemed to know from an early age that he wanted to organize the haphazard trivia of his daily actions into formal order, to give them a shape and meaning. George Orwell, otherwise temperamentally distant from Gandhi, saw exactly the tensed, pageant-like haracter of Gandhi's life, and its status as a theatrical parable, when he observed of Gandhi that 'his whole life was a sort of pilgrimage in which every act was significant.' What gave every act its significance was its place in a larger story. Indeed, the most subversive skill of this famously unarmed rebel was his ability to tell stories – stories that came entirely to redefine how people perceived themselves, and what they believed they could and could not do.

Nowhere did Gandhi deploy this skill to more powerful effect than when it came to his own life: it enabled him not merely to turn his life into a story, but to *live* it as a story. That skill is clearly manifest in the book you now hold: a magnificent, puzzling, strenuous act of self-creation, which describes – as it enacts – the metamorphosis of a fearful, unsuccessful provincial lawyer into a leader who dominated India's politics for almost four decades, and who took on and successfully defeated the British imperial state.

What drove this transformation was Gandhi's capacity for self-creation, or, as he termed it, his fascination with 'experiments' in living. He developed and refined this taste for experiment across the three distinct arenas in which he lived his life: England